

Express View on ASER report: Success in the classroom

During the Covid-19 pandemic, India had one of the longest school **closures** in the world. Digital learning locked **vast** numbers of **underprivileged** schoolchildren out of the classroom and online classes struggled to replace the experience and quality of teaching in a physical classroom. Last year's Economic Survey **pointed out** that the **gap** between class standards and learning levels **has widened** since the pandemic. It noted that "improving learning outcomes and **undoing** the Covid-induced learning loss is more urgent than ever". The survey, however, **struck a note of optimism**: "The education sector is **bustling** with the **across-the-board** transformation led by the NEP 2020, which is expected to **yield** foundational literacy and numeracy (FLN) skills for every child passing the third standard in the near future."

The latest ASER **report**, released on Tuesday, **shows** that this **optimism** was not **misplaced**. It shows that classrooms have not only recovered from the disruption caused by the public health emergency, **in several respects**, the foundational **skills** of primary and secondary-level school children today **are** much better than even that of their **counterparts** in the year just before the pandemic.

What is even more **heartening** is that government schools are **at the forefront** of this recovery. A large **chunk** of the **credit**, as the ASER report points out, **should** go to the New Education Policy's **thrust** on improving foundational learning skills. It notes that though states have **adapted** the NEP's prescriptions in different ways, all of them have adopted the policy's teacher-centric approach. The **large-scale rollout** of teacher training programmes on foundational skills **shows** a national commitment towards **addressing a longstanding deficit**. The training is slowly **leaving a mark on** the ways teachers relate to students in classrooms.

The ASER **surveyors** found that many teachers are now **empathetic** to the specific needs of students in the early years of school. However, as ASER 2024 indicates, educating educators is still a work in progress. There cannot be a fixed **pedagogical template** to teach children in all schools even if they are in the same grade — a fact **underlined** by the NEP as well. Today, teachers seem to have limited opportunities to address classroom-specific challenges. The ASER report, therefore, underlines the importance of post-training support to teachers. Crucially, decisions on what and how to teach are still based primarily on syllabus completion.

"Resolving the **inherent contradiction** between ensuring universal FLN and syllabus completion is a question that the system has yet to **reckon** with in a systematic way," the ASER report points out.

Today, more than 100 million children are in the foundational learning stage. When these youngsters graduate from school, the country would be at a critical stage in releasing its **demographic dividend** — that **window** would then be open for at most another **decade** and a half. Therefore, while policymakers can justifiably be **upbeat** about the good news from the ASER survey, they would be

mistaken in not reading the report in its **entirety**. They must give particular attention to the passages that underline the tasks ahead. The future's **at stake**.

[Practice Exercise]

- Red/blue coloring of words in the sentence indicates subject verb relationship; where 'red' denotes 'subject' and 'blue' denotes 'verb'.

@mocks_wallah

Vocabulary

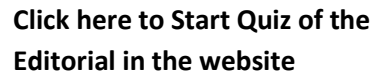
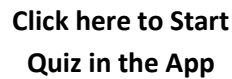
1. **Closure** (noun) – shutdown, cessation, stoppage, termination, conclusion बंदी
2. **Vast** (adjective) – huge, enormous, extensive, immense, very large विशाल
3. **Underprivileged** (adjective) – disadvantaged, deprived, needy, impoverished, poor वंचित
4. **Point out** (phrasal verb) – indicate, mention, show, highlight, draw attention to इंगित करना
5. **Widen** (verb) – broaden, expand, enlarge, extend, increase in scope विस्तार करना
6. **Undo** (verb) – reverse, negate, nullify, revoke, cancel रद्द करना
7. **Strike a note of** (phrase) – express, convey, communicate, adopt a tone of, give an impression of एक भाव या संकेत प्रकट करना
8. **Optimism** (noun) – hopefulness, positivity, confidence, cheerfulness, sanguineness आशावाद
9. **Bustle** (verb) – be full of activity, hustle, move energetically, swarm, buzz चहल-पहल होना
10. **Across-the-board** (adjective) – comprehensive, universal, widespread, general, all-encompassing व्यापक
11. **Yield** (verb) – produce, result in, generate, provide, give उत्पन्न करना
12. **Misplaced** (adjective) – inappropriate, misguided, unwarranted, undeserved, wrongly placed ग़लत साबित हुआ
13. **In several respects** (phrase) – in many ways, in multiple aspects, from various angles, regarding multiple facets कई मामलों में
14. **Counterpart** (noun) – equivalent, parallel, match, analog, corresponding person or thing समकक्ष
15. **Heartening** (adjective) – encouraging, reassuring, pleasing, uplifting, inspiring उत्साहवर्धक
16. **Be at the forefront** (phrase) – lead, spearhead, be in front, be a pioneer, be in a leading position अग्रणी होना
17. **Chunk** (noun) – portion, segment, part, section, piece हिस्सा
18. **Credit** (noun) – recognition, acknowledgment, praise, commendation, admiration श्रेय
19. **Thrust** (noun) – main focus, emphasis, drive, principal objective, core aim जोर
20. **Adapt** (verb) – modify, adjust, alter, tailor, customize अनुकूलित करना

21. **Large-scale** (adjective) – extensive, wide-reaching, massive, broad, expansive बड़े पैमाने पर
22. **Rollout** (noun) – launch, introduction, release, implementation, deployment आरंभ
23. **Address** (verb) – tackle, deal with, attend to, handle, resolve समाधान करना
24. **Longstanding** (adjective) – long-established, enduring, deep-rooted, old, chronic लंबे समय से चला आ रहा
25. **Deficit** (noun) – shortfall, deficiency, shortage, lack, insufficiency घाट
26. **Leave a mark on** (phrase) – impact, influence, affect, make an impression on, shape छाप छोड़ना
27. **Surveyor** (noun) – examiner, inspector, assessor, observer, investigator सर्वेक्षक
28. **Empathetic** (adjective) – compassionate, understanding, sympathetic, caring, sensitive सहानुभूतिपूर्ण
29. **Pedagogical** (adjective) – educational, instructional, teaching-related, didactic, academic शैक्षणिक
30. **Template** (noun) – pattern, model, blueprint, guide, framework नमूना
31. **Underline** (verb) – emphasize, highlight, stress, underscore, draw attention to ज़ोर देना
32. **Inherent** (adjective) – intrinsic, innate, built-in, essential, fundamental अंतर्निहित
33. **Contradiction** (noun) – inconsistency, conflict, disagreement, paradox, clash विरोधाभास
34. **Reckon** (verb) – consider, calculate, think, regard, anticipate मानना
35. **Demographic dividend** (noun) – The economic growth potential from changes in a population's age structure, typically when the working-age population is larger than the dependent age groups. जनसांख्यिकीय लाभांश
36. **Window** (noun) – opportunity, opening, interval, time frame, chance अवसर
37. **Decade** (noun) – ten-year period दशक
38. **Upbeat** (adjective) – optimistic, positive, hopeful, cheerful, buoyant आशावान
39. **Entirety** (noun) – whole, completeness, totality, fullness, unity समग्रता / संपूर्णता
40. **At stake** (phrase) – at risk, on the line, in jeopardy, under threat, in question जोखिम पर

Summary of the Editorial

1. **Pandemic Impact on Education** – India had one of the longest school closures during COVID-19, affecting underprivileged students and widening learning gaps.
2. **Challenges of Digital Learning** – Online education failed to replace in-person teaching, worsening disparities in learning outcomes.
3. **Economic Survey Warning** – The 2023 Economic Survey emphasized the urgency of addressing COVID-induced learning losses.
4. **Optimism from NEP 2020** – The survey highlighted the NEP's role in improving foundational literacy and numeracy (FLN) for young learners.
5. **Positive Findings in ASER 2024** – The latest ASER report reveals that classroom learning has not only recovered but improved beyond pre-pandemic levels.
6. **Government Schools Leading Recovery** – Public schools have played a crucial role in the post-pandemic educational rebound.
7. **NEP's Influence on Learning Outcomes** – The focus on foundational learning under the New Education Policy (NEP) has contributed to progress.
8. **Teacher-Centric Reforms** – Large-scale teacher training programs have enhanced classroom interactions and teaching effectiveness.
9. **Growing Teacher Empathy** – Educators are more attuned to students' specific learning needs, improving engagement in early education.
10. **Need for Classroom-Specific Approaches** – ASER highlights that a uniform teaching method cannot be applied across all schools, reinforcing NEP's flexibility in pedagogy.
11. **Limited Post-Training Support** – Teachers need more opportunities to address classroom-specific challenges beyond their initial training.
12. **Syllabus vs. Learning Outcomes** – There is a systemic conflict between completing the syllabus and ensuring universal FLN skills.
13. **Demographic Dividend at Stake** – With over 100 million children in foundational learning, their future success is crucial for India's economic and social growth.
14. **Need for Continuous Reforms** – While progress is visible, policymakers must focus on unresolved issues highlighted in the ASER report.
15. **Urgency of Action** – The next decade is critical for ensuring that India fully capitalizes on its youth potential through sustained educational improvements.

Practice Exercise: SSC Pattern Based



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